

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur



FOLLOW THESE GREEN IMPERATIVES

Anyone planning a tree plantation drive would do well to heed these words of wisdom from groups that got onto the right path after a few missteps **P5**



DEPARTED FOR ANOTHER SANCTUARY

V. Guruswami leaves behind a flock of admirers in naturalist circles **P7**



'Lay a proper road to Puzhuthivakkam station entrance'

A MURUGARASAN

The MRTS electric train services between Velachery and St. Thomas Mount started operating a few months ago. But the entrance to the

Puzhuthivakkam railway station from the Balaji Nagar side requires proper black-topping or patchwork.

Hundreds of commuters from Madipakkam, Puzhuthivakkam and Nanganallur use this entrance to ac-

cess the station. Proper road-laying or effective patchwork will be helpful to commuters getting to station by two-wheelers.

Southern Railway should do the needful at the earliest.

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Madambakkam residents have a new hangout

BEENA ANIL

Residents of Shridhi Sai Nagar in Madambakkam are on cloud nine after the opening of a recreational facility in the locality. On

June 7, the park was inaugurated by D. Sarath Kumar, Member of

Legislative Assembly, Tambaram Constituency. M. Veerappan,

Collector, Chengalpattu District, and S. Balachander,

Commissioner, Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, participated. The dream project did

not happen suddenly, residents had to wait for more than a decade. Shridhi Sai Nagar

Kudiyiruppor Nala Vazhvu Sangam office bearers were persistent with their demand. There were setbacks as the project was

stalled due to funding shortfalls and administrative delays. Another achievement

was the restoration of a well in the park by Chola and Exnora International. A dedicated play

equipment zone for children, a walking path, an open lawn for recreation, seating areas and a fountain are among the attractions of this space.

Beena Anil is a resident of Shridhi Sai Nagar



The play equipment zone at the Shridhi Sai Nagar park in Madambakkam, and (below), D. Sarath Kumar, Member of the Legislative Assembly, Tambaram Constituency, addressing the gathering at the inaugural ceremony.

Tambaram-Madurayoval Bypass Road still has dark spots

R V BASKARAN

After repeated representations and agitation, the National Highways Authority of India provided lighting along the Tambaram-Madurayoval Bypass Road.

On May 31, I travelled on the highway from Ambattur Industrial Estate junction to Tambaram.

A few stretches on this route still has dark spots including a one-km stretch after Vanagaram towards Tambaram and a two-km stretch along the flyover at the Porur Lake crossing. These



stretches are marked by bends.

The vehicular traffic along the bypass road has increased manifold in the recent past.

Motorists and motorcyclists entering the unilluminated sections have difficulty in crossing.

R V Baskaran is a resident of Selayur

'Renaming Velachery Main Road will inspire youngsters to join the Army'

V. SEETHARAMAN

On June 11, Tambaram City Municipal Corporation approved a resolution to rename Velachery Main Road after Major Mukund Varadharajan.

This is a good and welcome move by the civic body. Mukund Varadharajan was killed in action during a counter-terrorism operation while on deputation to the 44th Rashtriya Rifles battalion in Jammu and Kashmir. He was posthumously awarded the Ashoka Chakra, India's highest peacetime decoration, for his actions.

Renaming the vital stretch along which so many regions, including Selayur, Pallikarainai, Medavakkam and East Tambaram, are located and which sees heavy traffic is a fitting tribute to the officer's bravery and sacrifice for the nation. The stretch begins at Velachery junction along Guru Nanak Road and ends at the East Tambaram bus terminus along MES Road.

This will definitely inspire more youngsters to join the Indian Armed Forces and serve the nation in the days to come.

Major Mukund's *alma mater*, the prestigious Madras Christian College, is located along the stretch in the East Tambaram region.

V. Seetharaman is a social and environmental activist and a resident of Rajakilpakkam

Introduce mini bus services from Nemilichery

P. KARTHIKEYAN

I request Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) to introduce mini bus services in the Nemilichery region.

Earlier, there was route number 52E, which plied between Broadway and Nemilichery. Due to a long waiting period at Radha Nagar Gate (Level Crossing 27), the service lost patronage and was discontinued. At present, a subway has been constructed along the gate but only light motor vehicles can take the underpass.

A new bus shelter has been constructed for Nemilichery halter, and there is ample open



space to park buses without disrupting the regular traffic.

It is located on the Kovilambakkam-Pallavaram Municipal Limit Road, an Other District Road

(ODR). Currently, the route extending through the Pallavaram taluk office to Vels University, which provides connectivity to the Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam

200-Foot Radial Road, is constrained by narrow streets.

If the State Highways Department extends this ODR to connect (directly) to Radial Road, the region's transit gap will be bridged. Until the road is extended, the MTC must operate mini buses on main roads.

The four possible routes are: Nemilichery to Chennai International Airport Metro Terminal, Tirusulam, via Padavettamman Temple, Nemilichery, Pallavaram taluk office, and Vels University, to the Radial Road.

Nemilichery to West Tambaram: Beriamman Temple (Srinivasan Street, Postal Colony, Chromepet), Hasthinapuram, Chitlapakkam Lake, and Tamba-

ram Sanatorium.

Nemilichery to St. Thomas Mount Metro Terminal: A direct feeder service via interior roads in Madipakkam.

Kovilambakkam to Chromepet: A cross-corridor link via Nanmangalam, Nemilichery, Padavettamman Koil, and Vels University, till Chromepet railway station.

Currently, residents are dependent on private modes of transport or engage autos and autodrivers charge huge amounts to ferry them to Chromepet railway station and its halts, and Vels University halterovers on GST Road and Radial Road.

P. Karthikeyan is a resident of Ganapathypuram, Chromepet

Half measures in Vengambakkam

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of Thiruvengadapuram in Vengambakkam have appealed to Agaramthen Village Panchayat, Saint Thomas Mount Panchayat Union to lay the streets in the area.

For years, three stretches, Third, Sixth, and Eighth Streets, have remained unpaved leaving residents to negotiate uneven and sandy surfaces.

Although Fifth Street was black-topped, it was done only at certain points.

A. R. Lakshmanan, a resident, says, "Many a time, I have raised a complaint, but no action has been taken. When road-laying work began on Fifth Street, the contractor responded that he had been in-



Fifth and Sixth Street in Thiruvengadapuram-Vengambakkam region.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

structed to lay the road in this manner."

No name boards

There are approximately eight streets in the locality, but none of them has a name board, resulting

in frequent confusion for postmen and delivery personnel. Often, we must guide them with landmarks to ensure our deliveries arrive, which is inconvenient for both residents and the delivery staff, says Lakshmanan.

Relocate the garbage bins from 48th Street



Walkers to the Arthanareswarar Temple Pond walkway in Nanganallur want garbage bins on 48th Street Extension removed.

The stretch comes under the jurisdiction of Zone 12 (Alandur) of Greater Chennai Corporation.

Opposite the boundary walls are a row of garbage bins and a couple of non-functional e-toilets. Public dump garbage outside the bins and relieve themselves on the pavement.

The worst affected are pedestrians navigating the stretch, who have to walk on the carriageway amid trash, open toilets and vehicular parking.

Resident M. Prabhu Mohan says that traffic movement is sometimes affected.

V. Ramanujam, a resident of Nanganallur, says that along the



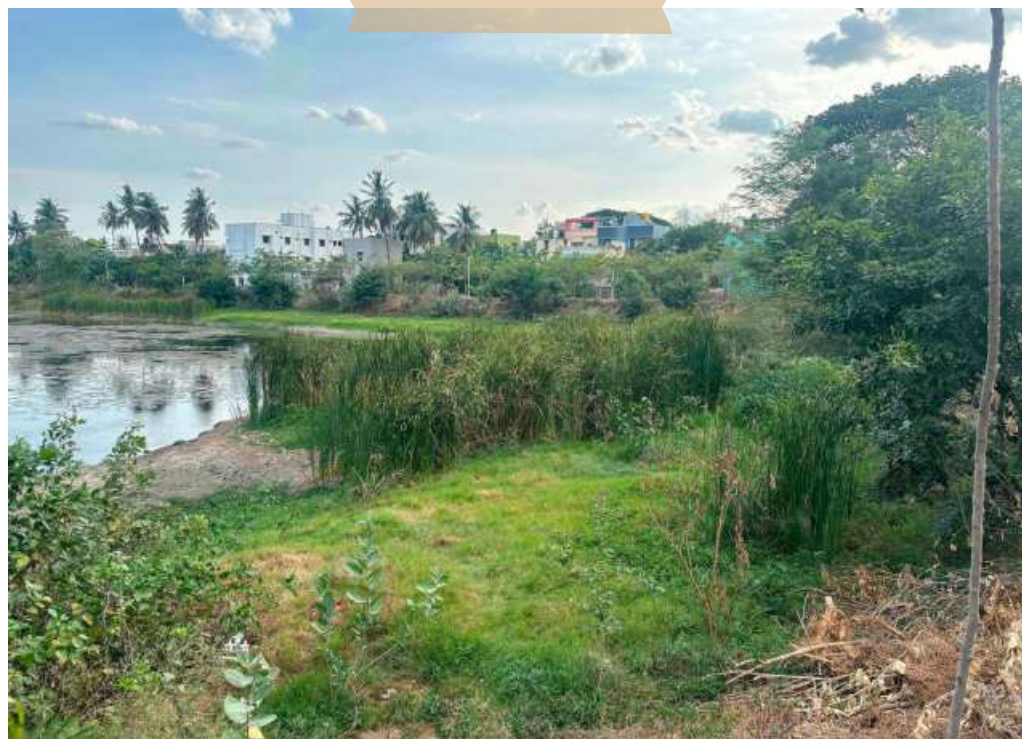
pond's boundary walls, a row of vehicles is parked.

Behind and along the vehicles, men consume liquor and relieve themselves.

The areas along the road have become an open toilet.

The street is not disinfected, resulting in breeding of mosquitoes.

Text: T.S Atul Swaminathan



Desilt Chitlapakkam Eri at the earliest

As these images show, in parts of Chitlapakkam Eri, the water-holding areas have dried up. Further, the water-holding areas are covered with vegetation and grass and littered with trash, which can reduce water storage capacity during the monsoon.

The 2025 monsoon deficit, the non-receipt of water from Pachaimalai (one of the lake's main water sources), and this year's severe heatwave have dried the lake to a great extent, says L. Sundararaman, president of the Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar Welfare Association. The Association has requested the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to clear the vegetation and deepen the lake to 5 feet to increase its capacity and store rainwater. TEXT AND PHOTO: T.S ATUL SWAMINATHAN



Beach litter segregated and sent for recycling

A number of awareness programmes were conducted on World Oceans Day 2026

A total of 1,260 kg of marine litter was collected during a beach clean-up and marine litter classification programme at Kovalam beach to commemorate World Oceans Day 2026.

The event was jointly organised by the National Institute of Ocean Technology (NIOT) and the Ocean Society of India (OSI), Chennai Chapter, in association with the Department of Civil Engineering, SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST), Kattankulathur.

Around 80 participants, including NIOT scientists and staff,



SRMIST faculty members and students, Kovalam school students, Coastal Security Group members, local residents, and volunteers, actively participated in the programme, said a release.

Of the 1,260 kg of marine litter collected, it was segregated into

textile waste (380 kg), plastic waste (340 kg), wood debris (290 kg), glass waste (150 kg), and other waste materials (100 kg). Recyclable materials were sent for appropriate recycling and disposal.

Later, an awareness programme was also conducted at the Govern-

ment Girls Higher Secondary School in Kovalam. NIOT scientists delivered lectures highlighting the importance of oceans, marine biodiversity, and the need to prevent marine pollution. Drawing and speech competitions were organised for students, and prizes were

Volunteers who took part in the event

distributed to the winners.

To encourage sustainable practices among students, seed saplings along with organic manure were distributed by NEEDS NGO for establishing home gardens. They also conducted a session on home gardening using recycled plastic materials.

The programme was conducted under the guidance of professor Balaji Ramakrishnan, Director, NIOT and Vijaya, Deputy Director, NIOT.

K. Thirumurugan, Scientist-E, NIOT, served as the convener, and R. Nagalakshmi, Associate Professor, Department of Civil Engineering, SRMIST, served as the coordinator. Members of the Ocean Society of India actively participated in the programme.

700 students take part in All India Inter-University Powerlifting Championship



Hindustan Institute of Technology and Science hosted the prestigious All India Inter-University Powerlifting Championship for the 2025-26 academic year at its Chennai campus. Organised from June 3 to June 8 under the aegis of the Association of Indian Universities and the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, the mega-event brought together over 700 elite student-athletes from 85 universities nationwide.

Chancellor Anand Jacob Verghese and Pro-Chancellor Ashok Verghese emphasised that the championship not only highlighted the university's international-standard sports

infrastructure but also served as a vital platform for cultural exchange, allowing participants from across India to experience Tamil Nadu's rich hospitality and rapid development. The competitive tournament, supervised by 70 certified technical officials, was inaugurated on June 3 by B.Vijayaraj, MLA, Thirupurur constituency and concluded with an inspiring valedictory ceremony led by Commonwealth Gold Medallist Arathi Arun and World Silver Champion V. Loganathan.

University of Calicut (*in picture*) and Bharathiar University were crowned as the women's and men's national champions respectively.

Lake walkway gets a dash of green

To mark World Environment Day, 150 saplings, including 100 mahogany and 50 bamboo saplings, were planted along the Kambar Salai Lake Walkway in Maraimalai Nagar.

The tree plantation drive was inaugurated by N. Narayanan, Commissioner, Maraimalai Nagar Municipality. Among those who participated were Mohan Krishnan, Director of Sports, SRM Insti-

tute of Science and Technology (SRMIST); V. Thirumurugan, Associate Director (Campus Life) and Nodal Officer, Unnat Bharat Abhiyan (UBA-SRMIST); S. Shanmugam, Chairman, Maraimalai Nagar Municipality; Chitra Kamalakanan, Vice-Chairperson; Dr. Bhuvaneshwari, Municipal Health Officer; and Sivamurugan, Sanitary Inspector.

The participants highlighted the

importance of environmental conservation, urban greening and protection of waterbodies. They also stressed the need for proper maintenance of saplings to ensure their growth and long-term ecological benefits.

The initiative was aimed at enhancing the green cover around the lake and creating awareness among residents on the importance of preserving natural resources and promoting sustainable development, said a press release.

Saplings planted at Medavakkam lake



To celebrate World Environment Day, Seerakku, a non-governmental organisation, planted more than 500 native tree saplings along the bunds of Periya Eri.

Around 500 students and IT professionals (members of the NGO) came from different regions to take part in the drive. The NGO members have promised to take care of the saplings.

Play to be staged at Chromepet Cultural Academy



The Chromepet Cultural Academy (CCA) will stage a drama, 'Thoduvaana Manidhargal' by N. Mahalingam, popularly known as 'Kudanthai Maali,' on June 14 at the academy's premises on Indira Gandhi Cross Street, off Radha Nagar Main Road, Radha Nagar. The play will be staged at 6.45 p.m. For details, call G. Nagarajan, the academy's secretary, at 9444690174.

Follow these green imperatives

A resource for the Environment Month: anyone planning a tree plantation drive would do well to heed these words of wisdom from groups that got onto the right path after a few missteps

LIFFY THOMAS

‘Get a declaration from the site owner’

In 2014, when Thuvakkam began its journey, the first project had to do with the greening of a patch on a campus. But as luck would have it, that green patch eventually gave way to a building with classrooms.

Lesson learnt: extract a promise from the owners of the patch, whether government or private, that the patch will stay green. But the same challenge has dogged us through the years, particularly where government-owned sites are concerned: there is no telling what will become of a patch that has been given a dash of green.

Recently, at a public park where we had undertaken a greening initiative, the government constructed an anganwadi, resulting in the removal of trees. Imagine our disappointment! For an ongoing project at a parcel of land owned by the Southern Railway, we have got a written assurance that the land will not be touched for five to eight years.

Krishna Kumar Suresh, founder, Thuvakkam

‘Make them allies’

After a plantation exercise at a government school in Puducherry, the headmaster called me days later to say that many of the saplings were missing. The needle of suspicion pointed to the students. I was shocked to learn that students had taken the saplings of fruit-bearing trees probably to grow them in their own backyard.

Lesson learnt: make them allies. This incident taught us the need to start a ‘Green Brigade’ where we give each child a free fruit sapling. These plants find their way into homes of students and other public spaces where they are nurtured by children. Under the Green Brigade initiative, we have so far given away many saplings.

To promote a sense of ownership, we started the practice of having a name board created at every plantation site. This has the name of the farmer responsible for nurturing the plants along with details of the plant species. But at one drive, I noticed that many saplings were left to wither in a corner, unplanted, as the people entrusted with the job of planting them had left the scene. After this episode, we make it a point to have the nameboard put up only after all the saplings are planted.

Prasiddhi Singh, founder, Prasiddhi Forest Foundation

‘Keep a backup plan in place’

We had planted more than 8,000 saplings on a 24-acre land owned by SIPCOT, Vallam Vadagal only to find that more than 60 per cent of them withered one harsh summer. The local civic body was providing water for these saplings and due to some reason the supply stopped affecting some young plants that needed water the most. Jackfruit and a medical plant used for cancer were the biggest victims.

Lesson learnt: one cannot rely on any institution for the continued survival of the saplings one had planted. So, before taking up such a massive exercise, have a Plan B, one particularly geared to meeting the saplings’ water needs. Knowing the soil, the groundwater table and the kind of trees planted is important.

At the same OSR site where we are growing a Miyawaki forest and raising a regular plantation, we have now arranged a 20,000 litre tank with a private supplier refilling it. We have replaced the lost plants with new ones.

Lt. Col. N. Thiagarajan, general secretary, Mastermind Foundation

‘Let go; or hang on till they see reason’

As part of their CSR initiative, a corporate had given us a list of plants they wanted us to grow and maintain, but a majority of those plants were not suited for Chennai’s climate. We tried explaining to the corporate how the location and the soil type plays an important role in the growth of plants but they would not listen.

In another case, an amusement park on East Coast Road wanted us to plant aesthetic-looking trees on their property. The problem with such trees is that they may not necessarily have a long life span and are not of much help to the ecosystem.

Lesson learnt: these two scenarios taught us to choose between two wise approaches. One, drop the project. Two, take up the work but make sure the client sees reason as you progress with the project.

Sreekumar Nair, founder, TREES

A second chance for everyday things

As a two-day garment mending workshop by Samposhan ends today, a close look at Chennai's repair culture provides cause for some celebration and also reasons to revitalise efforts to promote it

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Wire it right

At a time when malfunctioning appliances are often discarded with little thought, Repair Café Chennai is championing an alternative ethos, one that prioritises repair and recirculation.

Launched in October 2024 by Meenalochani S, founder member of Repair Café Chennai, the initiative traces its roots to the Repair Café movement started in Bengaluru by Purna Sarkar. The first Chennai session was held in the portico of Meenalochani's home, bringing together friends and their children for a hands-on introduction to repairing everyday objects. "It felt very much needed for every child as part of the skills they should grow up with," says Meenalochani.

The inaugural event featured stations for carpentry, cycle repair, and electrical and electronic repairs. Over time, however, the Chennai chapter evolved into a series of workshops focused primarily on

electrical and electronics repair. "The electrical and electronics section caught up with us because we found good mentors for it who were willing to continue the journey," she says. "My daughter got to open up the devices and identify the problem herself. Now she knows electronic goods can be repaired instead of simply buying new ones," says one of the participants.

Since then the collective has conducted workshops with a school in Besant Nagar, collaborated twice with Goethe Institute, and organised sessions in public spaces across the city. Most participants have been homeschoolers, with some families travelling from Puducherry



During a session at Repair Cafe Chennai.



Operating from his main outlet near Thirumangalam in Anna Nagar, with branches in Mogappair, T. Nagar, Ambattur and Padappai, Aasai Muthu restores saris damaged by age, wear and accident. Torn fabrics, damaged borders, colour bleeding caused by rainwater, rodent-inflicted damage and faded hues are among the most common problems brought to his workshop.

The craft is a "hand-me-down" to Aasai Muthu. "My grandfather and father were both weavers. From childhood, I was surrounded by saris and weaving work," he says. "Even now, I can easily identify different types of zari and borders."

His clientele ranges from homemakers seeking to preserve treasured possessions to actors and other prominent personalities. Wedding silks and heirloom saris account for a significant portion of the work he undertakes, particularly from customers in Mylapore. "Many people bring saris that belonged to their mothers or grandmothers. They do not want to throw them away because there are memories attached to them," he says.

Restoration charges typically range from ₹500 to ₹2,000, depending on the complexity of the work involved. While the repair itself generally takes three to four days, the entire process extends to six to eight days, including approximately two days each for collection and delivery. Customers may either visit the workshop or schedule a home visit, during which Muthu personally assesses the sari's condition. As part of the service, every restored sari is returned with a complimentary dry-cleaning treatment, helping revive its appearance and finish.

One of the more unusual assignments he recalls involved a government official who wanted the border from one sari painstakingly removed and attached to another. Such requests, he says, underscore the sentimental value that many customers continue to place on their garments.

Yet, Aasai Muthu has observed a gradual decline in the culture of repair. "Nowadays, many people prefer to sell old saris and buy new ones. Earlier," he says. The challenge becomes even greater when dealing with saris that are decades old. "Repairing a sari that is 30 or 40 years old requires a lot of patience. We cannot bring back the original material completely, but we can restore it and make it wearable again," he says.

Call Aasai Muthu at 6380563972

to attend repeatedly.

Through pre-registered sessions lasting three to four hours, participants learn troubleshooting, continuity testing, soldering and basic appliance repair under the guidance of volunteer mentors.

Fees range from ₹500 to ₹1,000.

The initiative also sustains an active WhatsApp community where participants seek repair advice and share resources. Looking beyond workshops, the group is working to build a gig-employment network connecting skilled repairers with those seeking repair services. "Our mission is to create earning opportunities, empower skilled workers, and connect them with people who need reliable repair solutions," says Meenalochani.

Instagram - @repaircafe.tiruandchennai

Stitching memories

When a treasured sari is torn, faded or damaged, Chennai-based sari repairer Aasai Muthu is often the person customers turn to.

With over 45 years of experience, Muthu has built a niche business around restoring saris that hold sentimental, cultural and monetary value.



The last day of a restoration workshop

Samposhan, the sustainability enterprise based in Adambakkam and founded by Mamta Jain, has brought together environmental consciousness and creativity through a two-day mending workshop in Besant Nagar. Titled "Pause. Mend. Reuse.", the event (June 13 and 14) encourages participants to repair and reimagine worn garments, extending their lifespan while underscoring Samposhan's broader mission of reducing textile waste and promoting a circular economy. Through hands-on sessions, attendees learn mindful mending techniques and explore ways to give cherished pieces a new lease of life, demonstrating how a simple repair can be a small but significant act of sustainable living.

Instagram - @thesamposhan

Departed for another sanctuary

V. Guruswami leaves behind a flock of admirers in naturalist circles

PRINCE FREDERICK

In the morning of June 11, if any birder in the field noticed a sudden drop in chirps verging on stillness, let them know that these birds sensed an instinctive snapping of a tie, the departure of a soul that sought to understand them selflessly. Not to make it to scientific journals and put on learned airs; nor to engage in social-media engagement farming. In their world, he discovered his own, one devoid of artificiality and filled with effortless comfort.

That morning, V. Guruswami departed for another sanctuary. A long life (he was 96), one spent with a great degree of autonomy (he bounced back to full health after a stroke in the fog end of 2011 and was in fine fettle till the last week of his life) is certainly a measure of blessing. But what was truly Guruswami's blessing was his ability to bless others with his knowledge, unconditionally without expecting anything in return. He leaves behind a flock of friends (nay more admirers than friends) at Madras Naturalists Society, a repository of local naturalist wisdom. But anyone who has known him beyond birding field visits would instantly resist the temptation to pigeonhole him into the identity of a naturalist-birder.

The breadth of his knowledge was indisputably vast. To give an inkling, he could hold forth on the legendary kite flyers of Madras in the 1940s and in the same breath share the contents of his correspondence with Jim Corbett. He was rooted lo-



▼ V. Guruswami (September 25, 1930 - June 11, 2026), truly erudite and incredibly humble.

cally, deeply connected with the twin *jheels* (Manali and Madhavar) as well as the verdant Simpson Estate in Sembium (all of them close to his former address in Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar), but he had a global consciousness, always sharpened by a desire for knowledge, again not acquired for self-aggrandisement but to freely share with others.

His curriculum vitae would indirectly reveal how he went out of his way mining for knowledge in various fields.

"Guruswami was born on September 25, 1930, studied at CSI Kellet Higher Secondary School in Triplicane and graduated with a chemistry degree from Presidency College, Madras. He started working with the Ordinance Factory at Khamaria, Jabalpur, later moved to

Addison Paints at the Simpson Estate in Sembium where he joined as a chemist and retired as a production manager."

That note is oddly familiar; one comes across that kind of a bio all the time; only that this one is silent on an extra universe of pursuits. Silent on reams and reams on the koel vocalisation, listening in to the male koel's plaintive calls during the breeding season, year after year.

Silent on the incredible conservation story at the Simpson Estate, where he helped protect a heronry. Silent on the trends of various bird species he had documented and shared with journalists including this reporter. And silent on the numerous notes on the drift of things in various other fields he had penned, just for his delectation and those known to him. Unfortunately, much of this information was lost in the shifting of addresses. When he was advanced in years (in the early 2010s after his almost-magical recovery from the stroke) Guruswami and three other seniors in the family took the decision to move from Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar to a senior-friendly block of an apartment in Sholinganallur with the support of the younger relatives in the family. Guruswami remained unmarried, and enjoyed a deep connection with his family, immediate and extended, and he was the favourite uncle and grandpa, no contests there.

And it was in this space on June 11, Guruswami breathed his last, nay let out his last chirp, not far from the Pallikaranai marsh synonymous with winged residents and visitors.

Real estate firm organises celebratory event



Thiranthighai Real Estates recently celebrated its annual 'Kudumba Vizha 2026' in the city.

Held at MCC School auditorium in Chetepet, the festival brought together the firm's channel partners,

employees, business associates, and their families for an evening dedicated to recognition and inspiration.

Founded by K. K. Muniyanti, the organisation's chairman, the nearly four-decade-old firm has built a

strong reputation on trust.

Muniyanti reiterated the organisation's long-standing vision that every family should own a piece of land.

A major highlight at the celebration was the recognition of channel partners, team leaders, marketing managers, and employees through a series of awards and documentary-style presentations that showcased their success stories.

The leadership team comprising K. K. Munusamy, S. Arun Kumar, K.M. Srinivasan, and K.M. Hariharan unveiled upcoming residential projects under the Tiru Thanikai Infra City and shared the organisation's vision for the future.

Fiftieth show of Gopi Funchurian

Popular actor, mimicry artist, and stand-up comedian Badava Gopi will be celebrating the 50th performance of "Gopi Funchurian", a unique stand-up comedy and mimicry show, on June 20 at 7 p.m. at the Music Academy.

Unlike other conventional stand-up comedy sessions, this will offer entertainment for the whole family, said a release.

The 90-minute show will feature humour, mimicry, storytelling, sound effects, celebrity voice recreations, cricket-inspired moments, and amusing real-life incidents from Gopi's life journey.

In a release, Badava Gopi said, "Mobile phones and YouTube videos cannot recreate the energy, laughter, and atmosphere that audiences experience live watching Gopi Funchurian. The show is to be felt, and enjoyed together as a family."

The 90-minute show will start at 7 p.m. Tickets are available on BookMyShow.

For details, call 9962886000
Website: www.badava-gopi.com



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Chennai cannot do without air-conditioners, but their run time can be reduced if one designed their living space green and topped it with soft furnishings that have the visible imprint of nature. Here are roadside conversations with makers of bamboo and *vetiver* curtains

Rooting for green cooling systems

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

At the time of writing this (for the times-tamp-obsessed: the afternoon of June 11), the sun has been served a memorandum of suspension for its obnoxious behaviour in the past few days. An overcast sky has ensured the fiery orb stays out of work. Clearly a reprieve from what was an unusually harsh beginning to June, generally known as the pre-monsoon season even in the sun's long-held fiefdom, Chennai. Just as a lioness would deal an overly exuberant cub a surprise paw swipe, the joy could be short-lived for the Chennai people. Put it down to climate change, the weather has the vacillating mind of a Hamlet, and so it can be hot again before you know it. And it might not be too late still to "insulate" your house with cost-effective, heat-reducing traditional props. In any case, the benefits would carry over to the next summer and the ones beyond.

Here is a cherrypicked solution, one lying under one's feet. It is curtains made of *vetiver* (*chrysopogon zizanioides*), an aromatic perennial grass native to India that comes with an air of reverence, its fragrant roots occupying the front row in pujas. Off the religious altar, it is patronised for its cooling properties. When woven into curtains, *vetiver* comes into its own. A recommendation not to be ignored: *vetiver* curtains (also known as *khus* curtains) can be teamed with bamboo curtains for coverage of greater surface area, factoring in cost, the former taking a slightly oversized bite out of the wallet, and maintenance, the former again being the difficult one.

Why these nature-based solutions, NbS as they call them? This poser needs to be put to those who make a livelihood out of making these curtains. Enter S. Jagadeeshwaran and Nagarajan, who along with their teams, work by the roadside in Alwarpet and Adyar respectively, ironically soaking up the sun to help



people stay shielded from it.

With some assistance, a *vetiver* curtain can cut out the heat to some extent. Jagadeeshwaran explains that sprinkling approximately half a litre of water on the *vetiver* screens every morning and evening helps maintain a cool atmosphere, while the moist roots release a natural earthy aroma. "*Vetiver* stands out not just for its cooling properties but also for its herbal and medicinal benefits," says Jagadeeshwaran, owner of the family-run Jagadeeshwaran Bamboo Works on TTK Road. Jagadeeshwaran makes *vetiver* curtains too.

With a life span of approximately two years and costing

around ₹200 per square foot, *vetiver* curtains, says Jagadeeshwaran, can be an ally in keeping the sun in check. Let us not hoodwink ourselves into the outrageous, even hare-brained idea that *vetiver* or for that matter bamboo can replace technology-based cooling systems (aka fans and air-conditioners).

Along with sustainable design of the house, these natural curtains can reduce the use of air conditioners, thereby resulting in savings on the power bill. But the house has to be prepared for them. They would fare better in a house with a generous provision for cross-ventilation. They do not so much cool a space as

keep unwanted stuff such as too much sunlight and pollutants out of it. Having said that, the water-sprinkled *vetiver* curtains do bring in a whiff of cool air, but only so much.

Their environmentally friendly nature should be a strong incentive to pair them with tech-based cooling solutions.

Bamboo versus vetiver

Nagarajan, a maker of bamboo as well as *vetiver* curtains in Adyar (near the Aavin parlour park) is a believer in *vetiver* curtains, but tends to bat longer for bamboo curtains. From a design perspective, bamboo curtains stand out. With those roots, *vetiver* curtains can resemble the inside of an angler's worm box. In contrast, the neat lines of the bamboo strips, horizontal, vertical or cross-stitched, make the curtains aesthetically more pleasing.

"Available in a range of colours and finishes, bamboo curtains can complement different architectural styles while helping lower indoor temperatures" Nagarajan adds. Then, the cost equation. Nagarajan notes bamboo is also the more economical option, costing around ₹100 per square foot, against the price of ₹200 per square foot *vetiver* curtains come at. He adds that bamboo products are particularly popular among resorts, hotels and homeowners looking to combine functionality with visual appeal, whereas *vetiver* curtains are predominantly preferred by individual households seeking a traditional cooling solution. With electricity tariffs ever on the rise and heatwaves becoming more stinging, Chennai residents should not ignore these traditional options. Beyond being money-wise, this would signify a return to a sustainable practice that was once the norm, and now takes an article such as this to remind ourselves of their continuing relevance.

S. Jagadeeshwaran can be contacted at 9841565239/9003183916 and Nagarajan at 9941538328.

'Building design key to effectiveness of bamboo and vetiver curtains'

Architect and co-founder of Design Co Lab, Pavithra Sriram on when these traditional curtains, which she clubs among "materials that breathe", can be effective: "The curtain system itself, whether it is a *vetiver* curtain or a bamboo curtain, is the last step of this entire spectrum. You are looking at a building that has to be designed in such a way that there is cross ventilation. Unless you do that, your reliance on air-conditioners is not going to stop. One *vetiver* curtain in an extremely developer-built apartment that lacks cross ventilation cannot suddenly make for Ooty climate. The entire building needs to respond to the local context. It is important not to look at these things as topical, band-aid solutions. They need to be understood as part of a holistic approach. The entire building environment has to work together. When that happens, elements such as bamboo curtains, *vetiver* screens and other traditional materials can play a meaningful role in improving comfort and reducing dependence on mechanical cooling systems."